3. Three-day basketball focus

Audience: Charles — deadline pressure
Goal: One clear “done” for the simplified model, without scope creep.
Status (2026-07-27): Re-entry bar **reached** — narrative, slide (`Model.pdf`), Alex Pass A bundle on disk. **Pass B (ρ ablation)** in progress via `540_*` — see `model_OPORD.md`.

What “done” means (72-hour bar)

Binding check: You can say in one breath: *Hero = outcome;* ***environment*** *=* `L_net` *(B − D, peers help and hurt);* ***selection*** *=* `S_i` *(Alex score — who gets the slot); sim = test congestion in* ***selection****, not one giant environment model.* (`../BINDING_Selection_is_its_own_step.md`)

You can stop spiraling when you can honestly say all four:

1. **I can explain the hero** in one minute (doc 01) — including **talent baseline** vs **hero** (two empirical axes).
2. **I can explain three layers** without merging them — unified nest `S_i = A_i + λ(B−D)`, Alex v1 **(B−D)=−L_C**, knockout **λ=0** (doc 02).
3. **I have a side-by-side figure**: empirical hero + generative sim, same advancement rate on Y, labeled axes.
4. **I have one limitation sentence** ready for Alex (below — copy when needed).

You do **not** need: bin-for-bin sim match, Rivanna sweeps, **τ** calibrated to 530, tenure figures, manuscript Word inking, or refreshed Army plots in this window.

Minimal model for Alex's intent (v1 — what he asked for)

Piece	What it is	Status
Empirical phenomenon	**Naïve:** P(draft | own **A_i**) ≈ monotone; **Hero:** P(draft | **PoolQ_LOO**) with tail dip	Done (530; doc 01)
Two-step generative	**(1)** assign to pools (ρ); **(2) S_i → top K**	`540_*` + `Model.pdf`
Unified selection	`S_i = A_i + λ(B−D)`; Alex v1: **(B−D)=−L_C** ⇒ `S_i = A_i − λ·L_C`	Locked (doc 02)
Headline sim test	**Knockout λ=0** (**S_i = A_i**) vs congestion in score — same league	**Done** (`hero_model_reset_bundle.py`)
Side-by-side + limits	Empirical + generative PNG; no bin-for-bin claim	**Done** (export folder)
ρ ablation	Vary assignment assortativity, **fix** selection rule — "is sorting involved?"	**Pass B** — `540_rho_ablation_bundle.py`

One line for Alex: *Hero is the stylized fact; the minimal generative proof is congestion* ***in the selection score*** *(Pass A knockout done);* ***ρ*** *ablation tests whether assignment sorting moves the readout with selection held fixed.*

Limitation sentence (v1 — use as-is or lightly edit)

> *The empirical stylized fact uses leave-one-out teammate quality among college players; the generative proof-of-concept selects on a score that penalizes leave-one-out viable-peer congestion and plots binned selection rates on a matching quality axis. We do not claim bin-for-bin reproduction of every ventile in v1; we claim that talent-only selection is insufficient and that congestion in the score can bend advancement curves in a disciplined artificial league.*

What is already built (do not rebuild from scratch)

Piece	Status	Where
Empirical hero (Layer A)	Done	`530`; `sports/datasets/mbb/exports_inverted_u_v0/alex_side_by_side_v0/`
Quadratic LPM ($\beta_2 < 0$)	Done	`lpm_hero_coefficients.txt` in export folder
Generative knockouts (λ=0 vs congestion)	Done	`generative_knockout_*_16quantile.csv`; script `sports/scripts/hero_model_reset_bundle.py`
Side-by-side PNG	Done	`inverted_u_side_by_side_empirical_vs_generative.png`
Narrative slide	Done	`Model.pdf` / `Model.pptx`
Plain readout	Done	`generative_knockout_summary.txt`, `side_by_side_caption.txt`

Re-run bundle if needed: `python sports/scripts/hero_model_reset_bundle.py`

Five-minute self-test (you're done when these pass)

1. **Hero (60 s):** Naïve vs Hero; tail dip is **outcome on pool axis**, not "NBA ignores talent."
2. **Binding (20 s):** doc 03 binding sentence or `Model.pdf` opener.
3. **Knockout (20 s):** same league; **λ=0 → S_i=A_i**; else **S_i=A_i−λL_C** with **(B−D)=−L_C**.
4. **Open side-by-side PNG** — left empirical, right generative; one honest limit.
5. **Read limitation sentence** once without hedging.

Suggested schedule (if still orienting)

Day 1 — Layer A

- Empirical hero PNG + doc 01; describe tail dip and **talent baseline**.

Day 2 — Layer C (selection knockout)

- Side-by-side PNG + knockout CSVs; λ toggles `L_C` **in selection**, not **ρ**.

Day 3 — Package for Alex

- `Model.pdf` + side-by-side + limitation sentence (email or brief).

Pass B: ρ sims (assignment ablation)

Question: Is assortative grouping (**ρ**) involved? **Answer:** Yes in the **full** story (step 1 — who lands where); **not** the minimal proof that congestion in **selection** matters (Pass A — **λ / L_C**, already run).

Run: hold **S_i** fixed (**λ**, **L_C** rule); vary **ρ** (low vs high) + sort-and-chop benchmark; same 16-bin readout on **poolq_loo**. Script: `python sports/scripts/540_rho_ablation_bundle.py`. See `../../sports/540_READ_ME_SIM.md`.

Explicitly out of scope (park guilt here)

- Bin-for-bin replication of hero ventiles from simulation
- Separate estimation of benefit vs congestion on one axis
- **ρ** calibrated to match hero before minimal story is sent
- Multi-domain Λ sweeps (Army slot capacity)
- Tenure Cox / Setting 3 prose
- Re-reading agent correspondence rounds

If you get pulled into cross-references again

Rule: Close the tab. Return to `00_READ_ME_FIRST.md`.

Agents: when Charles is in re-entry, **do not** point him at `Charles_reading_list.md` items 1–14, Pertinent Thoughts, or nesting note until he finishes re_entry 01–03.

One paragraph to end the reset

You started over because the **reference surface** exceeded your **working memory**. The science for Alex v1 is **on disk** and **in your slide**. Remaining work is **Pass B ρ packaging** (optional with Pass A) and Alex presentation — not re-deriving the model. Everything else waits in PARKED_FOR_LATER.md.

When you want depth beyond the slide, see `3-Master_Plan/plans/20260721_hero_model_reset.plan.md` — not before doc 02 feels easy.